

Learning Perception and Attribution

Introduction

Managers of organizations are expected to achieve the goal set forth by higher authorities. The individual workers, in turn, are expected by their respected managers to perform and achieve certain goals assigned to them. However, managers and individual workers operate in environments where other people can seriously affect their own individual performances. This reality brings out in the open the need to understand why people behave as they do.

Dealing more effectively with people requires knowledge of the relevant aspects of behavioral change, specifically learning, perception and attribution. Whether the individual, manager or otherwise, will survive or succeed in the organization will depend not only with the proper application of conceptual and technical skills but also human skills which could be enhanced with knowledge of learning, perception, and attribution.

LEARNING

Acquiring a complex set of sophisticated skills is a result of change that comes from learning. An understanding of how people learn is very important because it will help people explain and predict behavior.

What is Learning

Learning may be defined as a relatively permanent change in behavior or knowledge due to experience. When a person behaves differently from what he previously did, it can be said that there is change in the person's behavior. With change there is learning.

A change in behavior happens due to any or both of the following:

1. Learning; or
2. Other causes such as drugs, injury, disease and maturation.

A changed behavior is manifested by outward actions like frequent yawning.

Behavioral change starts with the mind when it accepts new knowledge. Sometimes, the mind "orders" the body to show some signs of behavior that is different from the previous one. Sometimes, the mind is just plain contented with the new knowledge and do not make attempts to "order" the body to show some outward manifestations of behavior change. Consider the following example:

Mr. Leopoldo Amparo read a book about the dangers of smoking. He was convinced that smoking is not good for his health and he decided to quit. His circle of friends liked what he did and they gave him more opportunities for social contacts with them.

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Obviously, Mr. Amparo's behavior change is a result of an indirect experience, i.e. reading books. Two aspects of behavior are apparent in Mr. Amparo's case: knowledge about the bad effects of smoking, and the outward manifestation of quitting smoking. Mr. Amparo had the option of just satisfying himself with the knowledge that smoking is bad, but he considered following up his knowledge with appropriate action. The result was a visible change in his behavior.

THEORIES OF LEARNING

Eminent researchers have developed theories that help explain the learning process. These theories consist of classical conditioning, operant conditioning, and social learning.

Classical Conditioning

Classical conditioning may be defined as a type of learning in which a stimulus acquires the capacity to evoke a response that was originally evoked by another stimulus. A stimulus is something that incites action. An example of stimulus is "demotion in rank". The response could be "a law suit".

An illustration of classical conditioning is provided as follows:

When a horse is trained to pull a calesa or carromata, the trainer is confronted with the problem of how to regulate the speed of the horse. The trainer uses a whip to make the horse run faster.

Before the trainer strikes the horse with the whip, he taps the wooden part of the rig as a preliminary move. The horse reacts positively whenever a strike is made by a trainer.

Later, whenever the trainer taps the wood, the horse reacts quickly without waiting for the whip to perform its function. The reaction of the horse towards the wood tap is called "conditioned response" and the process is called classical conditioning.

The application of classical conditioning in the workplace is too important to be ignored. For instance, it was one Monday morning in a typical factory when Mr. Honesto Lumauig was called by the manager to the office and he was asked why his last week's output was very low. All throughout the interview, Mr. Lumauig felt nervous and very uncomfortable.

Seven days later, and it was Monday morning again and Honesto begins to feel nervous and uncomfortable. nervous and uncomfortable. He can hardly concentrate on his job.

In this case, the "original stimulus" is the Monday morning when Honesto was confronted by the boss. Honesto's "response" was that he felt nervous and uncomfortable. Any Monday is a "neutral stimulus", but it becomes a "conditioned stimulus" when paired with the original stimulus.

When confronted with a "conditioned stimulus", Honesto reacts with a "conditioned response", i.e., he feels nervous and very uncomfortable.

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Operant Conditioning

Operant conditioning may be defined as a type of learning where people learn to repeat behaviors that bring them pleasurable outcomes and to avoid behaviors that lead to uncomfortable outcomes.

For instance, if an employee receives cash rewards every time he exceeds his assigned targets (e.g., 100 units of tables produced per month), it is very likely that he will repeat such behavior. In the same light, if a salesman who achieves the minimum sales requirement for a given period is allowed to use a company vehicle in his daily rounds, it is also very likely that he will avoid doing something that will reduce his sales output. Both the employee and the salesman have learned to behave through operant conditioning.

At this point, a question may be asked: How is classical conditioning different from operant conditioning? Classical conditioning involves adjustment to events (or stimuli, whether conditioned or otherwise) over which the concerned person has no control. In contrast, operant conditioning involves adjustment to situations in which the actions of the person determine what happens to him.

Social Learning

Social learning may be defined as the process of observing the behavior of others, recognizing its consequences, and altering behavior as a result. One of the ways by which people learn is through social contacts with other people. For instance, an employee pays much attention to his boss, a highly successful person, whenever he speaks or just plain moving around the office. The brief encounters with the boss gave the employee the opportunity to understand and apply some ideas shared by the superior. An example is watching the boss perform the right way to communicate with customers.

How Social Learning is Achieved

Social learning may be done in three ways namely:

1. by observing what happens to other people;
2. by being told about something; and
3. through direct experience.

PERCEPTION

When an accident happened in the workplace, two persons actually saw it. Later, when both were asked to provide details about the accident, their statements differ in several aspects. How may this discrepancy be explained? The answer is: different perceptions of the same event.

When a situation, as in the above case, happens, it will be difficult for the decision maker to make an accurate evaluation of what really transpired, and the quality of his decision is affected. This underscores the importance of knowing the various concepts and theories ascribed to perception.

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Perception may be defined as the process by which people select, organize, interpret, retrieve, and respond to information from their environment.

Factors Influencing Perception

Perception is influenced by the characteristics of the following:

1. the perceiver
2. the target
3. the situation

The Perceiver

The person who perceives the target is the perceiver. His perception of the target is influenced by factors that are unique to him, like the following:

1. his past experiences
2. his needs or motives
3. his personality
4. his values and attitudes

A person's experiences in the past have some bearing on his current perceptions. For instance, a child who had an unpleasant experience with a surgeon will not maintain a good perception of physicians when he grows older

The Target

The person, object, or event that is perceived by another person is the target. Perception may be modified by the following factors which are typical characteristics of targets:

1. contrast
2. intensity
3. figure-ground separation
4. size
5. motion
6. repetition or novelty

The foregoing characteristics may be briefly described as follows:

If during the perception process, the target is situated in a background of contrast, perception is affected. For instance, when a boy is seen with five girls, perception will be different than when he is with five boys.

Intensity varies in terms of brightness, color, depth, and sound, and because of these, perception is affected. For instance, a person will be seen differently when the illumination is different from the usual one, say from an incandescent bulb to a bright blue fluorescent bulb. Another example is the singer who is well appreciated by the audience because his voice is projected well by an appropriate sound system. He will not be so regarded when he uses a poor device.

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The figure and its ground is a factor that may affect visual perception. The figure is the one being looked at, and the ground is the background against which it stands. For example, you saw your best friend speak before a crowd on two occasions: one is when he delivered his piece in an oratorical contest in school and second, when he was speaking before a crowd of rallies situated near Malacañang. Your perception of your friend on those two occasions will differ, thanks to the differences in the nature of the backgrounds.

The size of the target is also a factor that may affect perception. Those that are smaller or larger than the average are perceived differently. For instance, it is expected that the farmer who harvested a mango fruit twice the size of the average mango will handle the fruit with a little more concern.

Size matters even in the placement of company personnel. A research undertaken some years ago indicates that the taller persons have better chances of promotion.

In terms of motion, moving objects are perceived differently from stationary objects. For example, a housewife who is doing her routine buying in the market perceives fish that is aggressively jumping as more fresh than the one that is alive but is barely moving.

Repetition affects perception. For example, when a person is repeatedly exposed to a particular music, that person gets used to it and chances are, he becomes fond of it. When love at first sight does not work, familiarity may do the trick.

The Situation

Perception is also affected by the surrounding environment. For example, a person who is enjoying a meal with tribal people in the hinterlands may be well received even if he uses his bare hands. He will be perceived differently when he does the same in the dining halls of the privileged class in the city.

The situational factors that affect perception are: time, work setting, and social setting.

As people's moods vary from time to time, perception also varies depending on the time the perception is made.

Workplaces differ from one another. As such, perception also differs from workplace to workplace. For instance, the playing of soft music may be perceived favorably in a certain workplace but differently regarded in another workplace.

The social setting is also a factor in perception. For instance, a person will perceive a Caucasian girl as very pretty when both of them are situated in a remote place in the Philippines. However, when both are situated in a movie studio in Hollywood, U.S.A., the girl will be perceived differently.

ATTRIBUTION

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There are other theories that may be useful for a better understanding of human behavior. One of these refers to attribution.

Attribution theory is the process by which people ascribe causes to the behavior they perceive.

An example is provided as follows: An employee always feels very nervous whenever the office manager calls her to present her weekly report in the manager's office. Her anxiety affects her very much, including the delivery of her report. Her unit supervisor sympathizes with her and would like to help her overcome her fears. The supervisor started to monitor her moves so he can determine the reason for her behavior. The supervisor is clearly adapting the attribution theory to help her subordinate.

Common Attribution Errors

When people make attempts to determine the causes of other people's behavior, errors commonly happen. These errors may be classified into the following types:

1. the fundamental attribution errors, and
2. the self-serving bias

The *fundamental attribution errors* refer to the tendency to underestimate the influence of external factors and overestimate the influence of internal or personal factors in the behavior of others. For instance, the area manager of a retailing firm blames one of the store managers for failing to attract a sufficient number of customers rather than the poor location of the store.

The *self-serving bias* is that type of attribution error whereby people tend to attribute their achievements to their good inner qualities, whereas they attribute their failures to adverse factors within the environment. An illustration is provided as follows:

Dr. C. Agao is an employee of a state university. He and his factor in his recent promotion. When pressed by his colleagues for a superior are members of a fraternity. This relationship became a major comment on his promotion, he declared that he thinks he is better qualified than the others.

Within the span of five years, Dr. Agao failed miserably in his job. When his superior was replaced, he was demoted. Dr. Agao blames his co-employees.

Factors That Influence Attribution

When people try to determine the cause of a person's behavior, i.e., whether the cause is internal or external, some factors influence such effort.

The factors refer to the following:

1. distinctiveness
2. consensus
3. consistency

Distinctiveness

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The consideration given to how consistent a person's behavior is across different situations is referred to as distinctiveness. An example is provided as follows: Mr. Nick Cargada was recently hired by the university as driver. When he was asked to deliver a letter to someone in a nearby barangay, he used the school's motorcycle. Along the way, he hit a stray dog.

The next day, he was ordered to fetch five professors who attended a seminar in a nearby town. This time, he used the school's newly purchased van. On the way back, he hit a carabao resting on the right side of the road.

On the third day, he was directed to transport 50 student athletes to participate in a competition at a nearby province. The university bus was filled to capacity when he started driving. The bus was not yet ten kilometers from the university when it bumped an old man along the road.

Mr. Cargada's performance was declared disgusting and his co- employees attributed it to an internal cause, i.e., his personality.

Consensus

This refers to the likelihood that all those facing the same situation will have similar responses. For instance, if Mr. D. Ocleng and the other five employees in his unit failed to arrive in time, Mr. Ocleng's late arrival will be attributed to an external factor.

Consistency

This refers to the measure of whether an individual responds the same way across time. For example, Mr. D. Ocleng's performance in his previous assignments was declared unsatisfactory. First, when he was given the job as records clerk in the registrar's office of the university, he made a considerable number of wrong entries in the students' records. Second, when he was assigned as typist in the accounting office, he made incorrect entries in a number of checks he was processing. Third, when he was transferred to the supply office as inventory clerk, he failed to record a number of incoming stocks.

Based on Mr. Ocleng's behavior in the above-mentioned situations, he was declared a consistent incompetent by his superiors.

SHORTCUTS USED IN FORMING IMPRESSIONS OF OTHERS

For whatever reason, we form impressions of others. Those impressions constitute a database in our minds that we later use as aides in making decisions concerning others. For instance, Andres will not confide secrets to Pedro if Andres consider Pedro as a gossip.

People's perceptions may or may not be accurate, but accuracy is not a serious concern when opinions are found. Most often, people are not even aware that they are already judging others.

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Making sure that impressions of others are accurate is taxing and burdensome. It is impractical to collect through observation or otherwise information about a person covering many aspects of his activities. And so, people end up making shortcuts.

Most often, these shortcuts produce misleading conclusions and this should serve as a warning to people who make use of these shortcuts.

The shortcuts refer to the following:

1. selective perception
2. halo effect
3. contrast effects
4. projection
5. stereotyping

Selective Perception

Selective perception happens when a person selectively interprets what he sees on the basis of his interests, background, experience, and attitudes.

It is impossible for a person to assimilate everything he sees, hears, smells, touches, or tastes. Only a limited number of stimuli can be taken in. As a result, people engage in selective perception, but the process is affected by personal interests, background, experience, and attitude of the perceiver. For example, if a person had an unpleasant experience with food in a Thai restaurant, it will not be hard for him to perceive Thai people negatively.

Another example may be cited as follows:

When he was a teenager, Mr. Odeng was mugged by dark skinned persons

When he grew older, he found it difficult to relate with co- employees who are dark-skinned. His past experience would not allow him to make a positive impression of those kinds of people.

Of course, it is wrong, to, judge people with insufficient information

Halo Effect

Halo effect occurs when one attribute of a person or situation is used to develop an overall impression of the person or situation." For instance, a brilliant criminal lawyer may also be perceived by many to be also brilliant when he engage in selling real estate.

"Halo' refers to that ring of light just above the head of a saint as we see it in pictures or paintings. The "halo" signifies that everything about the saint is holy

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A person's outstanding achievement in one area may serve as his "halo" and he may be perceived as outstanding in other endeavors as well. Of course, this is not always true. A person who is good at selling must not be perceived outright as also good in training, recruiting, and collecting accounts. Even if the perception process is slow, it is still wrong if it is tainted with the halo effect.

Contrast Effects

A beautiful lady may be declared as the third prettiest in a certain place, but she could be number one in another place.

A job applicant may be rated very well in an interview because mediocre applicants were interviewed before him. The same applicant may be rated "poor" when he is preceded by bright ones in the interview.

Contrasting situations, oftentimes, lead to inaccurate evaluation of a person's character and ability.

With the examples cited above, contrast effects may be defined as evaluations of a person's characteristics that are affected by comparisons with other people recently encountered who rank higher or lower on the same characteristics.

Projection

Projection is attributing one's own thoughts, feelings, or motives to another. It is likely to occur in the interpretation stage of perception.

An example is the manager who is motivated to work mainly by the pay he collects each fortnight. He thinks that his subordinates share the same motivation, so whenever he had the chance to talk with his boss, he mentions the need to increase the salaries of people working in his unit. The manager is actually projecting his needs to his subordinates and his actions are inappropriate. His subordinates really need the money but not as the main reason for working.

Stereotyping

Stereotyping refers to judging someone on the basis of one's perception of the group to which that person belongs. For instance, a manager may think that older people are no longer productive. Based on that belief, he declined the job application of a 60-year-old person. The basis for the decision is unfair because he thinks that the applicant is a stereotype of what he believes. It may be true that many older people are no longer fit to work, but not all of them. The hiring of older persons by big retailing firms to entertain customers is proof of the ability of some older persons.

Summary

Knowledge about learning, perception, and attribution is very useful to someone who cares about the behavior of people.

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Learning is a relatively permanent change in behavior or knowledge due to experience.

Change in behavior may be due to learning or other causes like drugs, injury, disease, maturation, and many others.

There are theories of learning that help explain the learning process. They are classical conditioning, operant conditioning, and social learning. Classical conditioning is a type of learning in which a stimulus acquires the capacity to evoke a response that was originally evoked by another stimulus.

Operant conditioning is a type of learning where people learn to repeat behaviors that bring them pleasurable outcomes and to avoid behaviors that lead to uncomfortable outcomes.

Social learning is the process of observing the behavior of others, recognizing its consequences, and altering behavior as a result.

Perception is the process by which people select, organize, interpret, retrieve, and respond to information from their environment. Perception is influenced by the characteristics of the perceiver, the target, and the situation.

Attribution is the process by which people ascribe causes to the behavior they perceive. Attribution errors consist of fundamental attribution error and the self-serving bias.

Attribution may be affected by factors such as distinctiveness, consensus, and consistency. The shortcuts used by people in forming impressions of others are selective perception, halo effect, contrast effects, projection and stereotyping.

Assessment

Answer the following questions in a separate sheet of paper. Submit to your teacher via google classroom email or messenger.

File name should be [Surname/Activity 4/Leadership in Organization]
ex. **Dela Cruz Activity 4 Leadership in Organization**

1. What is learning? Why is it important for people to have an understanding of how people learn?
2. What is classical conditioning? What is a "conditioned stimulus"?
3. Regarding the theory of operant conditioning, what is avoided in the learning process?
4. How is social learning achieved?
5. What is perception?
6. Who is the perceiver? What factors influence his perception?
7. What is attribution?
8. What are the common attribution errors?
9. What factors influence attribution?
10. What is selective perception?

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